A-01 moved through the azure forest with the quiet confidence of someone who had mapped every twisted vine and basalt ridge a dozen times over. Her golden boots left a soft imprint in the Warped Nylium, the only armour she wore that night—just enough to keep the piglins from turning hostile. Nothing more. With a crossbow strapped across her back and a satchel heavy with gold ingots she'd smelted the day before, this wouldn't take too much of her time. Following the trail of cobblestone and torch markers she left weeks earlier, each one half-buried and half-overgrown, they led deeper into the arid red haze toward a known piglin bastion outpost.

The air smelled of sulfur and distant lava. Somewhere far off, a ghast's cry echoed and faded. But A-01 didn't slow. She had done this run so many times, the path felt like muscle memory. When the bastion walls finally rose ahead—familiar blackstone and gilded ones catching the faintest dim glow of the lava sea beyond—she paused only long enough to check her inventory one last time. Then, she stepped into the open courtyard.

Several piglins looked up from their gold-hoarding and bartering. Their ears and snouts twitched at the glint of her boots. A-01 raised both hands slowly, then tipped her satchel. Gold ingots clattered onto the cracked blackstone floor into a clank. At the sight, the reaction was immediate. Piglins shuffled forward, grunting and gesturing, tossing and offering items in return with the usual mix of eagerness and suspicion. One pushed forward a handful of ender pearls. Another offered some nether wart. A third, taller than the rest and wearing a golden helm slightly too large for its head, directly held out a clear glass bottle filled with a pale amber liquid that shimmered faintly in the low light amidst the crowd.

A-01 tilted her head in thought. She'd traded for enchanted books, for potions, for crying obsidian—but never for something that looked so much like a *drink*. The piglin grunted again and shook the bottle. Inside, the liquid swirled thickly.

Curiosity won. She accepted the bottle, nodded once in thanks, and backed away while the rest of the trade continued amongst them. A few more ingots changed hands for blaze rods and a pair of copper chestpieces she didn't really need. Then, she turned and followed her trail back the way she had come, the glass bottle tightly secured in her satchel.

The portal home was a relief for her eyes, its purple swirl a familiar comfort after the oppressive red of the Nether. A-01 hopped over the safety gates and stepped through without hesitation. The moment the cool Overworld breeze hit her face, she exhaled, rolling her shoulders. Night had already settled over the cave entrance. Only the distant inn and torches of the cart-rails glowed along the paths. She headed straight home, climbing up the path and towards the large, timber and sandstone structure she'd built. It served as the heart of their little settlement.

Inside, the main floor was quiet. On the right, a few empty mugs sat on the long table. Someone had left an enchanted book spread open near the window that was sure to be stolen at some point. A-01 walked up the spiral stairs to the attic without checking in the second floor. The room she shared with her roommate was exactly as they had left it that morning: empty furnaces, two beds pushed together, her wall of crafting tables. . . and a window looking out past the trees.

She took the glass bottle out of the satchel and set it on the bedside chest. Sitting on the edge of her purple matress—her side of the bed—A-01 simply examined the unusual drink. The liquid caught her diary's lantern light and glowed a soft honey-amber. She uncorked it with ease. The smell rose immediately—sharp, tingly, with something underneath that reminded her of the Nether: sulfur and musk. It wasn't unpleasant, just strange but somewhat familiar. Bringing the bottle to her lips, A-01 took a careful sip.

It burned. Not like fire resistance potions, which tasted purely medicinal with a pinch of ash. This was heavier, almost syrupy but light on the tongue before the heat spread down to her throat. Though she swore the smell of blackstone crept at the taste, it tasted a little like the Nether smelled after rain—if it ever had rain. But it smoothed out, almost pleasant once the first sting faded. She took a second, slower sip. Then a third.

A-01 leaned back against the headboard, bottle still in hand. The warmth settled, and after a while, her face began to feel a bit flushed. A pleasant heaviness gathered behind her eyes. She knew she was still coherent—still fully herself—but the edges of the room softened just a little, and the usual background awareness of every creak in the house and every distant mob sound outside grew fainter. She set the bottle on the bedside chest, corked it again, and decided sleep was calling her. Whatever this was, this could definitely help her with rest.

Pulling off her boots, she slid under the blankets in her outside clothes. The attic was comfortably cool. She closed her eyes and let the mild tipsiness rock her toward slumber.

She did not hear the soft footsteps on the stairs.

Her roommate had been downstairs finishing a late inventory count when the portal sound and the quiet footsteps overhead reached them. They knew that particular tread. A-01 was back from the nether. Finishing up the last few stacks and climbing up the spiral stairs more quietly than usual, her roommate poked their eyes into the attic room. Seeing A-01 already in bed, one arm outside the blankets, and face turned slightly toward the window. Her cheeks looked warmer than usual. The glass bottle sat on her bedside chest, half-empty.

They stood still for a long moment. Something tightened in their chest the way it always did when A-01 was close and unguarded. They could have taken their own side of the bed. They could have whispered a soft goodnight and tried so hard to leave space. Instead, something daring moved them forward.

Slipping off their iron helmet and leather boots, then carefully, they slowly climbed onto the shared mattress from the far side. The bed dipped only a little. Her roommate lay down on their side, facing A-01, close enough that their knees almost touched under the blankets. They watched the slow rise and fall of A-01's breathing and tried not to make a sound.

A-01 stirred. Her eyes fluttered, still a little heavy from the drink, and she turned her head. In the washed dim moonlight against the windows, she found them already looking at her, close enough that she could feel the way their breath caught when their eyes met.

They froze.

For a second, neither of them moved. The attic was quiet except for the soft night wind against the window and the distant lowing of a cow somewhere in the fields. A-01's gaze was clouded with something unreadable, but at the edges, it was soft. She studied her roommates face the way she studied new building blueprints—unhurried.

". . .Hey," she murmured, her voice a little lower than usual. "You're late."

Her roommate's heart was hammering so hard they were certain she must've heard it. "I—yeah. Inventory. You were in the Nether?"

A-01 made a small affirmative sound and shifted so she was fully facing them. The movement brought them a fraction closer. "Traded with the piglins. They gave me. . . that." She gestured vaguely toward the bottle. "Tastes like the Nether decided to make a nightcap. I'm a little warm."

They swallowed. "Are you okay?"

"Mhm. . . Yeah. Maybe a bit tipsy. Not bad." A-01's eyes stayed on theirs. Though the usual sharp focus was softened, a glint of knowing laced her eyes.

After a moment she added, quieter, "You're staring."
They felt a rush of warmth envelop them. "Sorry."

"Don't be." A-01 reached out from under the blankets and found their hand. Her fingers were warm. She didn't pull away. "You've been looking for a while, haven't you?"
The question landed gently, without accusation. Her roommates' breath left them in a soft, startled rush. They could have denied it. But, her gaze lulled them in. Instead, they nodded once, small and honest.
A-01's mouth curved in the faintest smile. She gave her roommates hand a light squeeze, then shifted closer as if their foreheads nearly touched.

"Then stop sneaking over like you're going to get caught. . . It's annoying."